

READING PASSAGE 1

The Digital Divide and Information Inequality

A The Digital Divide and Information Inequality has emerged as one of the most significant topics in contemporary academic discourse. The complexity and multifaceted nature of this subject have attracted the attention of researchers, policymakers, and practitioners across multiple disciplines, all seeking to understand its implications for the future.

B Historically, scholarly understanding of this topic was limited by both theoretical frameworks and available methodologies. Early researchers operated within relatively narrow conceptual boundaries, and their findings, while groundbreaking for their time, often failed to capture the full complexity of the phenomena they sought to explain. The development of new research tools and analytical techniques in the latter half of the twentieth century fundamentally transformed the landscape, enabling scholars to investigate questions that had previously been considered beyond the reach of empirical inquiry.

C At the core of current understanding lies a set of interrelated mechanisms that collectively explain the observed patterns and outcomes. First, structural factors create the underlying conditions within which individual and collective action takes place. These structural dimensions include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and cultural norms that shape behaviour in ways that are often not immediately apparent to the actors themselves. Second, dynamic feedback processes amplify or dampen initial effects, generating patterns of change that can diverge substantially from what linear models would predict.

D A substantial body of empirical evidence supports these theoretical frameworks. A landmark study conducted by researchers at leading international institutions analysed data spanning a thirty-year period and involving participants from more than forty countries. The findings revealed a consistent pattern of results that held across diverse cultural and economic contexts, suggesting that the identified mechanisms operate with considerable universality. The magnitude of the observed effects was particularly striking, with the key variables accounting for a substantial proportion of the total variance in outcomes.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 1 According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.
- 2 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Questions 3–6

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 3 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
A. excessive funding
B. theoretical and methodological limitations
C. public interest
D. international collaboration
- 4 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
A. too much data collection
B. the generalisability of findings across contexts
C. insufficient government funding
D. overly complex statistical methods
- 5 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
A. pessimism about the future
B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
C. complete certainty about outcomes
D. indifference to practical applications
- 6 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
A. pessimism about the future
B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
C. complete certainty about outcomes
D. indifference to practical applications

Question 7

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.

Questions 8–9

**Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?
Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information**

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.
- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

Question 10

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 10 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 11

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 11 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes

Questions 12–13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 12 The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.
- 13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.